

About Me

I was born in Kobo-Robit, a quiet rural town in Ethiopia, where electricity was a distant dream and clean water a luxury. For most of my childhood, I had never seen a light switch or a glowing screen. My schoolbooks were read by the flicker of a handmade kerosene lamp—built from a used bottle, a bit of wire, and a strip of cotton rope. Television, radio, or computers were beyond imagination.

Raised by my deeply spiritual grandmother, Emahoy Mulu Fentabil, I was guided not only by her values but also by the rhythm of rural life—tending to goats and cattle, praying in silence, and dreaming under the stars.

It wasn't until I moved to the nearby city of Kobo for Grade 11 that I experienced electricity for the first time. The shift was overwhelming. Suddenly, I could study at night, listen to radio programs, and attend an IT class that introduced me to a computer. I even mistook a local encyclopedia software for the internet—it took time to understand what true connectivity meant.

Despite financial challenges, cooking with wood and charcoal, and surviving on minimal resources, I persevered. In 2012, I enrolled at the University of Gondar, where I studied Electrical and Computer Engineering, specializing in Communication Engineering. After graduating top of my class with a CGPA of 3.89/4.0, I served as an Assistant Lecturer (2016–2017) and completed a Higher Diploma Certificate in Teaching Methods in 2017.

In 2018, I began a Master's program in Communication Engineering at Addis Ababa Science and Technology University (AASTU), completing the coursework with a perfect CGPA of 4.00. However, before defending my thesis, I was awarded a scholarship at Università degli Studi di Brescia, Italy, and chose to pursue an MSc in Communication Technologies and Multimedia. This program took me across Europe, including a 6-month Erasmus+ exchange at Mid Sweden University, followed by a thesis-abroad program at the Artificial Intelligence Institute in Ethiopia, where I explored deep learning methods for neuro-image retrieval.

In March 2022, I graduated cum laude (110/110 cum lode) and began an extraordinary internship at Poliambulatorio Oberdan, an advanced clinic for back pain diagnosis in Brescia. There, I was immersed in therapeutic follow-up, medical image acquisition, segmentation, and diagnostic data analysis. Inspired by the role of data, I pursued a 6-month Applied Data Science Lab certificate from WorldQuant University, mastering end-to-end data science workflows.

In December 2022, I started my Ph.D. in Artificial Intelligence in Medicine at the University of Brescia. My research focuses on AI-assisted technologies for spine-related pathologies, aiming to enhance clinical diagnostic workflows. During this journey, I have:

Served as a visiting Ph.D. student at the Center for Digital Health & Implementation Science (CDHI) in Ethiopia (September – Dec 2024),

And at New York University (April–Oct 2025), where I've contributed to MRI-based spinal pathology grading and domain adaptation research.

I've also deepened my academic toolkit through elite programs such as the:

Oxford Machine Learning Summer School (3 months),

IEEE ComSoc eHealth TC Ph.D. School (by the IEEE Communication Society),

Ph.D. School on Statistical Methods & Data Analysis in Medical Research at the University of Brescia,

And numerous international conferences and online seminars on medical AI and imaging. From lighting firewood under starry rural skies to programming AI systems in urban research labs, my story is a bridge between worlds—powered by hope, humility, and an unrelenting thirst for knowledge. I carry the spirit of Kobo-Robit into every model I build and every paper I write, always seeking to give back to the communities that shaped me.